

have in common?

Try to keep those educational traditions alive and have members of the next generation aspire to follow in your footsteps.

Marriage

What sort of people do you marry? Does your family tend to marry into other wealthy, socially connected families? Or does it tend to marry into hardworking salt-of-the-earth sort of families? Will the next fiancé fit well into your family?

In our family, we have a test for prospective spouses. We call it the “Gualfin Test,” after our ranch in South America. We invite him or her to come with us to the ranch. From the United States, it is a long and arduous journey culminating in five hours of rough mountain driving in a 4 × 4. Sometimes the road is washed out. Sometimes we have to turn back. When we finally get to the ranch, we are at an altitude of nearly 9,000 feet. It is very dry. Very hot in the day. Very cold at night. Typically, when we arrive, we stop for a cup of tea, and then get on horses for a four-hour ride to visit a remote valley.

How a boyfriend or a girlfriend handles the journey—and the stay at the isolated and arid ranch—tells us how he or she will fit into the family.

It used to be that successful multigenerational families would marry strategically; it was a way of social climbing. Or they would marry certain people to achieve strategic goals, such as forging a partnership with another wealthy family.

We doubt that this is advisable. People who “marry for money,” as they say, earn it. Seeing that the prospective spouse will fit with the family identity is more important. A lasting, stable, happy marriage is the most desirable outcome when it comes to family wealth.

Philanthropy

In many wealthy families that no longer own or manage a family business, the family philanthropy becomes a focal point of the family activity and